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Léa

May 1945

On the first of May, Léa, Josef, André and Rose gathered around the radio in the sick bay, listening to the broadcast: *the Führer has fallen at his command post in the Reich Chancellery, fighting to the last breath against Bolshevism and for Germany.*

“The war is over?” Léa asked, her voice hopeful as she gently rocked Katya in her arms.

Josef held up his hand, continuing to listen, then turned off the radio.

“They’ve appointed Admiral Dönitz as his successor.” He looked up at Léa. A ball of dread gathered in her stomach because she could see he was worried. “They’re putting on a brave face. The Soviet army seems to be in control of Berlin; they just haven’t announced it yet.”

“We must leave,” Rose said.

“Where will we go?” Léa asked.

“To the Allied side,” Rose said. “We don’t want to be here when the Soviets enter.”

“How far is that?” André asked.

“West of the Elbe River,” Rose said.

“How do you know that?” André’s tone was sharper than it needed to be, tight lines around his mouth.

Rose looked down. Léa could see her sister wincing inside but trying to hide it. Usually, she and André stood next to one another, sometimes holding hands if it was just the four of them. Not today. They were miles apart. Something had happened between them.

“Herr Reinhardt told me.” Rose looked up. “He warned that if we’re